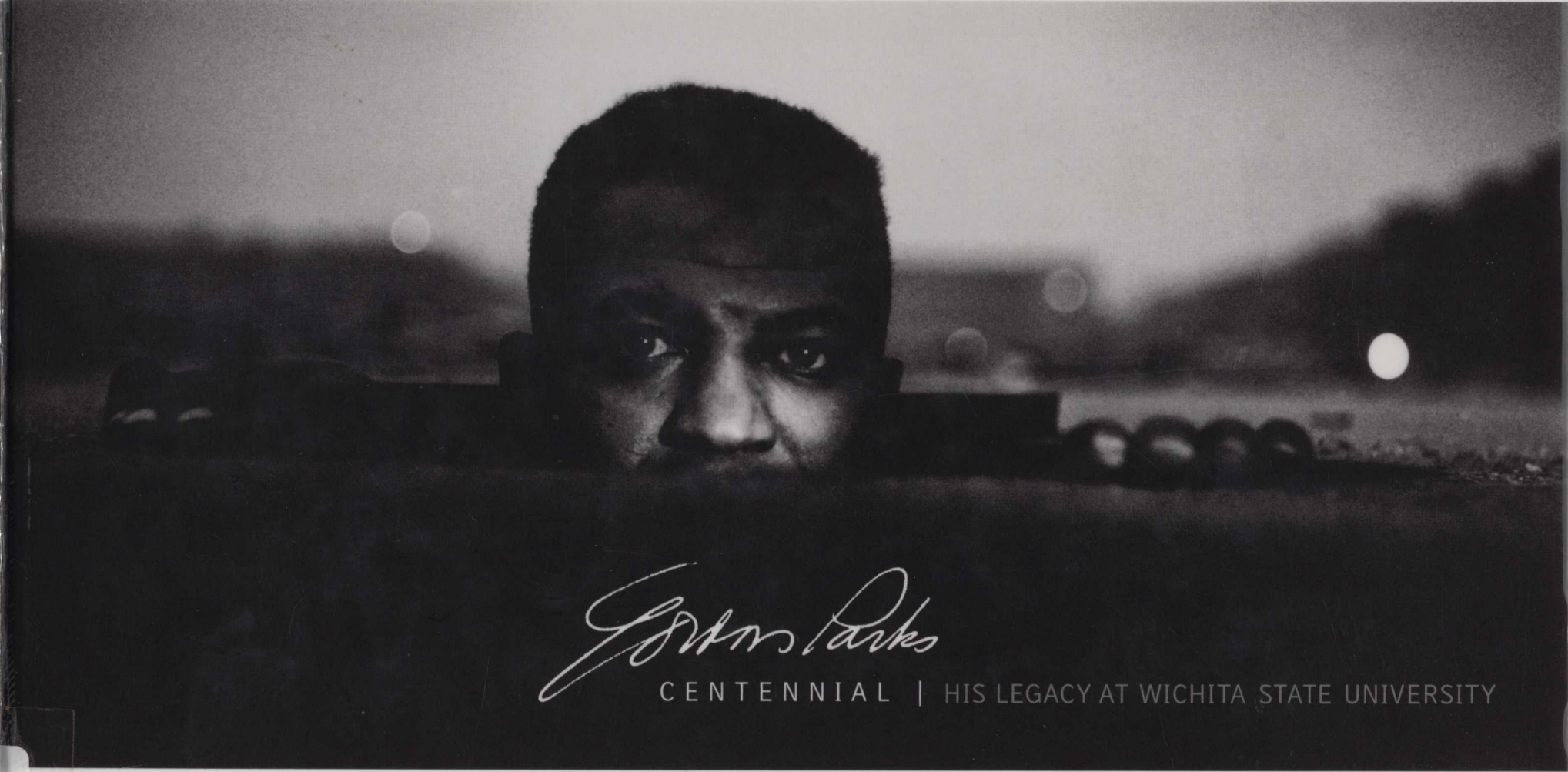




*After years of being a slave, I had learned And
 I had learned to be a slave. I had learned to be a slave.
 I had learned to be a slave. I had learned to be a slave.
 I had learned to be a slave. I had learned to be a slave.
 I had learned to be a slave. I had learned to be a slave.*



John Parks

CENTENNIAL | HIS LEGACY AT WICHITA STATE UNIVERSITY

placed hard work before complaining, and who preferred love
 and dignity to hatred. There was no profound judgment to be made.
 yet I was incapable of such. It was simply a matter of subcon-



LEFT | Gordon Parks, *American Gothic* (Ella Watson, Washington, D.C.), 1942, printed later. Gelatin silver print, 20 x 16 in. Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase. © and courtesy The Gordon Parks Foundation

In 1941, Gordon Parks was awarded a Julius Rosenwald Fellowship that allowed him to move from Chicago to Washington, D.C., and work for the Farm Security Administration, a project of the federal government begun in the 1930s that was largely dedicated to documenting the lives of Americans struggling through the economic depression. In Washington, Parks completed a series of photographs recording the life of a black cleaning woman named Ella Watson.



LEFT | Gordon Parks, *Eartha Kitt*, 1952. Gelatin silver print, 13 1/4 x 8 5/8 in. Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase. © and courtesy The Gordon Parks Foundation

RIGHT | Gordon Parks, *Duke Ellington, Recording Session*, 1960. Gelatin silver print, 13 1/4 x 9 in. Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase. © and courtesy The Gordon Parks Foundation

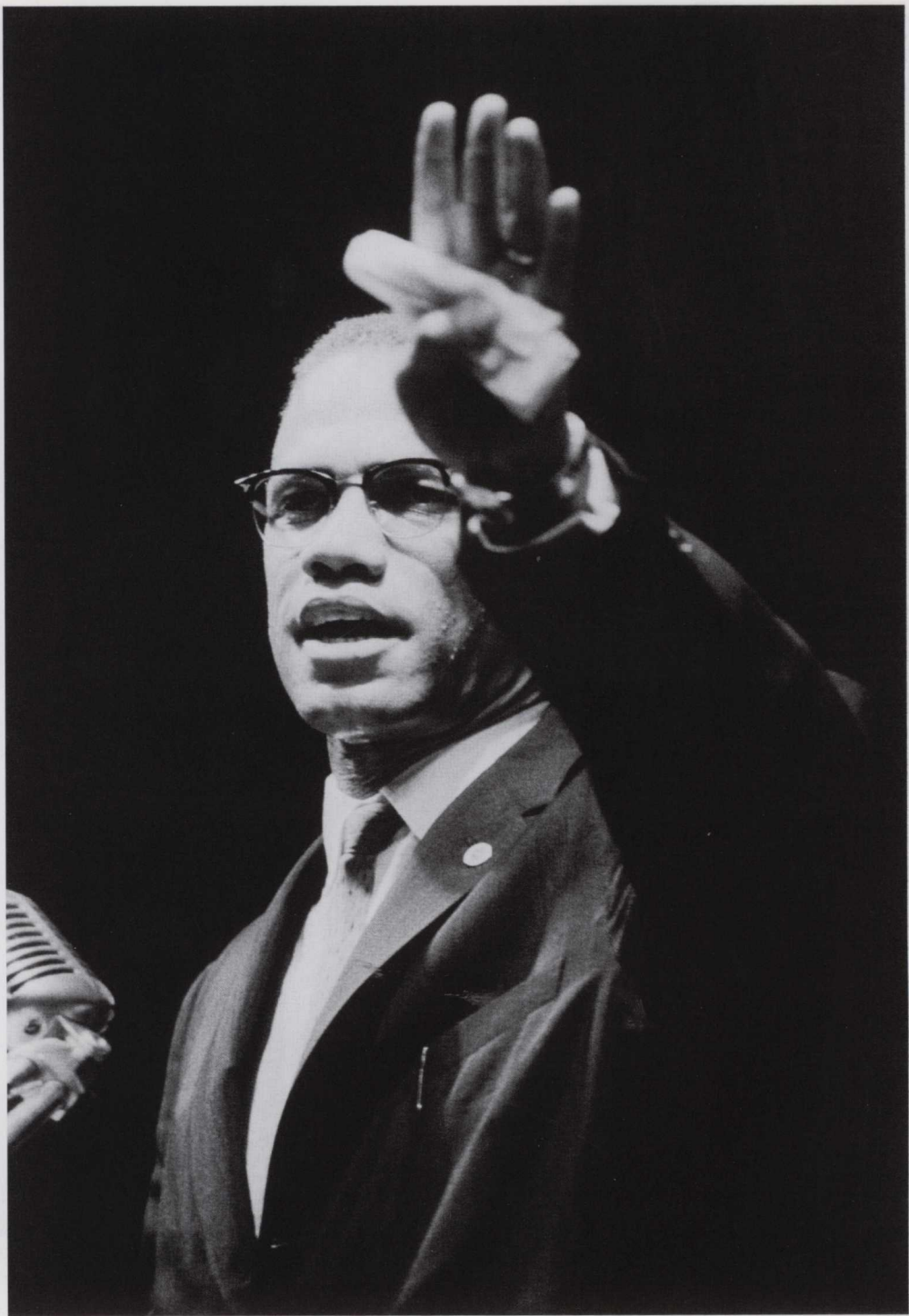




LEFT | Gordon Parks, *Department Store, Birmingham, Alabama*, 1956. Cibachrome print, 15 1/4 x 15 1/4 in. Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase. © and courtesy The Gordon Parks Foundation

RIGHT | Gordon Parks, *Malcolm X Addressing Black Muslim Rally, Chicago*, 1963, printed later. Gelatin silver print, 14 x 11 in. Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase. © and courtesy The Gordon Parks Foundation

Throughout the 1960s, *Life* magazine sent Gordon Parks to spend lengthy amounts of time with leading African American figures in the civil rights struggle. In many instances, sending a black photographer was the only way for the magazine to get the story. Some of Parks's iconic images from this time, such as this shot of Malcolm X, come from his photo essay "Black Muslim's Cry Grows Louder," which was printed in the May 31, 1963 issue of the magazine.





VICTIMS PAY \$90,000 FOR "JUSTICE"

25c

EXTRA

25c

Exclusive Muslim Story of:

**SEVEN UNARMED NEGROES
SHOT IN COLD BLOOD BY
LOS ANGELES POLICE**



VICTIMS PAY \$90,000

25c

EXTRA

Exclusive Muslim Story of:

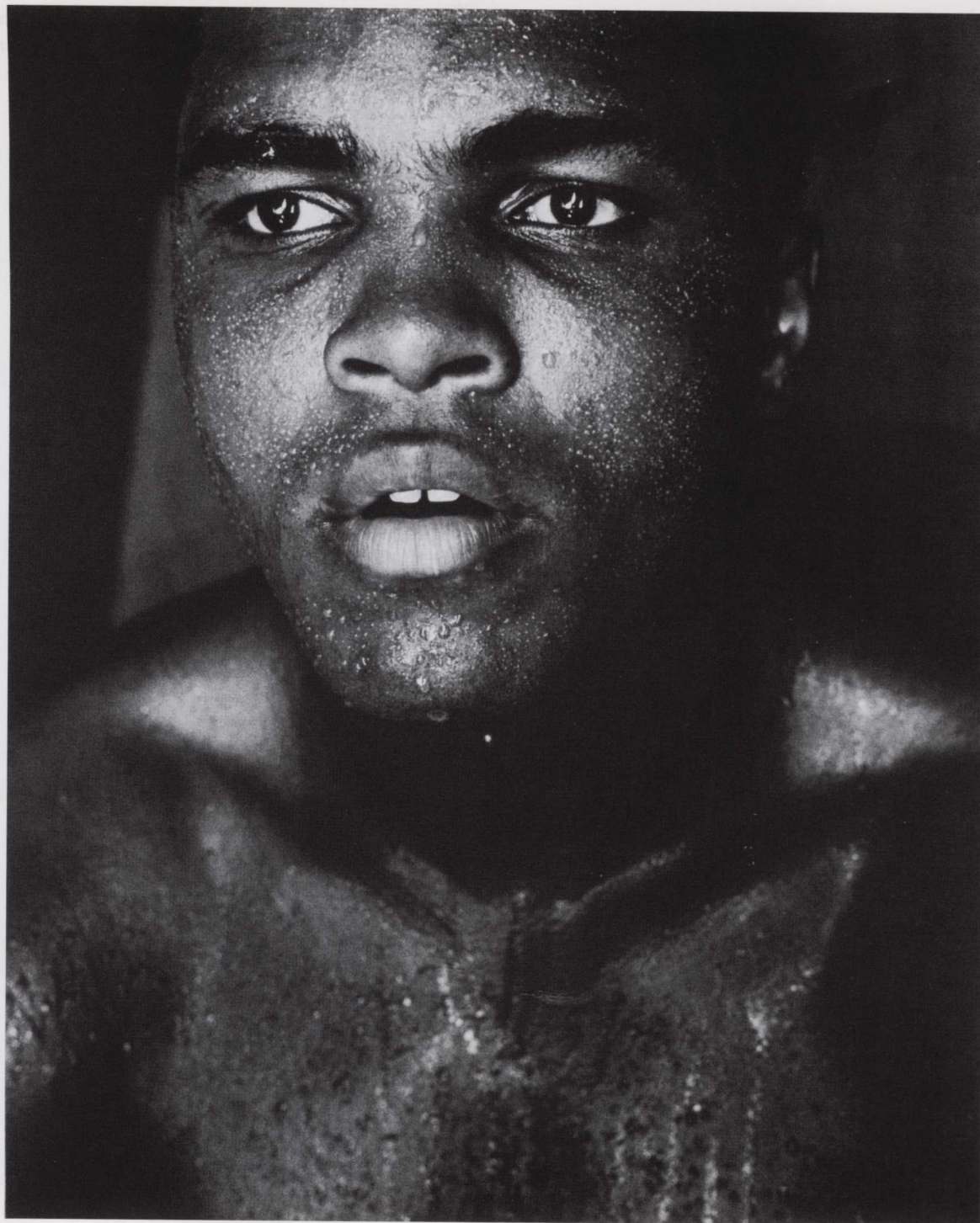
**SEVEN UNARMED
SHOT IN COLD
LOS ANGELES**



LEFT | Gordon Parks, *Black Muslims*
Distributing Newspapers, Chicago, 1963.
Gelatin silver print, 9 5/16 x 13 3/8 in.
Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase.
© and courtesy The Gordon Parks

RIGHT | Gordon Parks, *Muhammad Ali*, 1966,
printed later. Gelatin silver print, 14 x 11 in.
Ulrich Museum of Art, Museum Purchase.
© and courtesy The Gordon Parks Foundation

Often called "The Greatest," boxer Muhammad Ali was not always so esteemed. In 1966, he drew public ire for opposing the war in Vietnam and in response became confrontational with the press. That spring, *Life* magazine sent Gordon Parks to meet Ali. Although he disagreed with the athlete on many counts, the two formed a solid friendship.



BELOW | Letter from MGM story editor Russell Thacher (New York) to Jack O'Connell rejecting a film deal for *The Learning Tree*, July 6, 1966. Gordon Parks Papers, Special Collections and University Archives, Wichita State University Libraries

RUSSELL THACHER
EASTERN STORY EDITOR



Mr. Jack O'Connell
960 Madison Ave.
New York, N. Y. 10021

July 6th, 1966

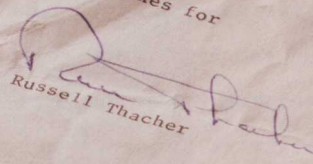
Dear Jack:

Sorry that I have been so long in reporting back to you on Gordon Parks' *THE LEARNING TREE*, but as I told you several times on the phone, I wanted to be sure not to hit Bob O'Brien at a time when he was unnecessarily pressed and thus jeopardize any true interest he might have had.

We have now discussed this and both Bob and myself have considered the project very seriously, but frankly we are not sufficiently certain of the commercial prospects of this venture to suggest going ahead with you on a firm deal. For one thing, we feel that the racial area is still a very tricky one, at least for a company such as MGM and besides this, our production schedule is so intense for the next year and a half we only feel justified in taking an active interest in projects which strike us as an absolute must. However much we may admire *THE LEARNING TREE*, it does not fall into this category.

Again many thanks for your patience and our best wishes for your success in locating it elsewhere.

RT:ab
enc. - Book - *THE LEARNING TREE*
by Gordon Parks


Russell Thacher



"I HATE DYIN' SO MUCH I WISH SOMETIMES THAT I WAS ALIVE EVEN

very
This ~~xxxxxxxxxx~~ statement of ~~xxxxxxxx~~ Newt's concern struck
the ~~xxxxxxxx~~ fibers of Sarah's ~~xxxxxxxx~~ knowledge. He was
edging
~~xxxxxxxx~~ her into an ~~xxxxxxxxxxxxxx~~ area of discomfort, one in which
blindness was a blessing.
~~xx~~ an ~~secretly~~ she hoped that
she said
what ever answer came from her lips, ~~xx~~
~~xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx~~ would be the right one final. *And* And when she saw his
face after ~~xxxxxx~~ blurting, "why I'm surprised at you sayin' such a
thing," she knew ~~xx~~ he realized that
for time, and that his next question would clamp her in the trap that
inevitably
~~stagnant~~ closed about her.

xxxxxxxx that
"Is there anybody who has ever come back from death ~~and~~ saw be
xx
xxxxxx... (who's this boy been talkin'
to... there's he gittin' such notions?)... "No, boy. Ain't no such
thing as that ever happened to my knowing."

expeded
His ~~xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx~~ next question was so inevitable that when